



Practices and Communication Protocols

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Work Practices

In an increasingly competitive business environment, the quality of service delivered by organizations can be a major differentiating factor.

Organizations that have demonstrated commitment to delivering quality service increasingly have the edge over their competitors.

ITWorks values its employees. We have implemented the best workplace practices, which include the day-to-day relationships that our employees experience.

Provide Clear Expectations

Create a culture where it is clearly stated:

- Vision, Goals, Roles & Values
- Results, Quality Standards, Timelines, Priorities
- Written lists of agreed actions and outcomes

Encourage the team to ask questions. Ensure the communication is clear, specific, and without any doubts.

Plan, organize and complete daily work

- Identify and interpret work instructions and priorities in consultation with the supervisor
- Determine and map out appropriate work plan or daily routine
- Determine, collect, and organize materials, resources, and information needed to complete work
- Complete work tasks within designated timelines and in line with quality standards and instructions
- Follow work health and safety policies
- Deal with problems that arise in a practical, timely, and appropriate manner and seek assistance when required
- Encourage people to contribute ideas and get involved in decisions
- Seek feedback on work performance and make improvements as required

Communicate effectively

- Identify appropriate lines of communication with supervisors, colleagues, and customers
- Use effective communication skills as well as literacy and numeracy skills, to gather and convey information
- Demonstrate appropriate non-verbal behavior

Work with others

- Identify work roles of self and others in the workplace
- Contribute to team outcomes in a manner that fulfills own work responsibilities and promotes cooperation and good relationships
- Interact respectfully with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds

Use workplace technology

- Select appropriate workplace technology to complete work tasks and use according to workplace and manufacturer guidelines and instructions
- Inspect workplace technology to ensure it is working properly and take precautions to reduce risks to technology and self
- Take appropriate action to address or report problems with workplace technology
- Care for workplace technology according to workplace and manufacturer guidelines and instructions

Solve work problems

- Identify problems and determine practical or creative solutions within the scope of individual responsibility
- Seek assistance from key personnel when required
- Report on workplace problems as required using workplace procedures

Adapt to change

- Identify, clarify, and accommodate new work requirements or situations
- Identify possible practical or creative options to deal with workplace challenges, and discuss them with the supervisor

Support Your Team

Know the staff: what is happening in their lives, what motivates them, and offering assistance when they are overloaded.

Communication Conventions and Protocols

The main purpose of communication is to present subject content to an audience in an organized, concise, and effective manner.

- Decide what forms of communication work best
- Plan and Prioritize
- Create work schedules
- Complete tasks efficiently
- Be respectful of other people's time.
- Clarify goals and tasks
- Identify work roles of self and others in the workplace
- Be clear about individual task responsibility
- Develop new visions/goals collaboratively
- Contribute to team outcomes in a manner that fulfills own work responsibilities and promotes cooperation and good relationships
- Be committed to resolving problems
- Value and respect each other
- Interact respectfully with customers and colleagues from diverse backgrounds (age, gender, culture, etc.)
- Establish and maintain rapport
- Conduct negotiations
- Encourage members to listen to and consult each other about matters that affect them
- Establish open communication
- Create a safe place to express feelings and ideas
- Be open to feedback
- Provide positive and constructive feedback to members
- Actively participate.
- Be an active listener.
- Take notes.

Oral Communication

Oral communication is the use of words to share information with other people. However Effective oral communication skills include more than just talking. Oral communication encompasses both how you deliver messages and how you receive them.

Characteristics of Oral Communication

- Active listening
- Asking for clarification
- Asking open-ended questions to gain insights
- Recognizing and responding to non-verbal cues
- Speaking clearly and concisely
- Using humor to engage audiences

Verbal Communications for Team Members: Open and constant lines of communication are vital to team success, particularly when completing quality- and deadline-critical projects. One of the most important team-building skills, strong verbal communication helps to ensure that issues will be spotted and resolved in formative stages, averting costly escalation.

- Conveying messages concisely
- Encouraging reluctant group members to share input
- Explaining a difficult situation without getting angry
- Explaining that you need assistance
- Paraphrasing to show understanding
- Posing probing questions to elicit more detail about specific issues
- Receiving criticism without defensiveness
- Refraining from speaking too often or interrupting others
- Requesting feedback
- Stating your needs, wants, or feelings without criticizing or blaming

Verbal Communications with Clients: If a large part of your work involves one-on-one communications, it's helpful to have a "gift of gab". Keep in mind, though, that your conversations need to be focused on identifying and addressing your client's needs; using your verbal talents to encourage consultative dialogues will ensure positive client relations.

- Anticipating the concerns of others
- Asking for clarification
- Asking open-ended questions to stimulate dialogue
- Calming an agitated customer by recognizing and responding to their complaints
- Emphasizing the benefits of a product, service, or proposal to persuade an individual or group
- Noticing non-verbal cues and responding verbally to verify confusion, defuse anger, etc.

Answering the Telephone

Customer Service Standard

We will answer all telephone calls promptly and in a manner that gives a good impression of the organization.

Within how many rings?	On or before 3 rings
Operations:	All phones will ring and must be answered within 3 rings.
What do we say?	"Welcome to ITWorks, this is..... (Your first name only)"
Asking for a client's name:	If the client does not clearly state their name or you are unsure who you are talking with: "Can I just confirm who I am speaking with?" "And your name is...?"
How should we sound?	Smile in your voice. Friendly Voice well-modulated and clear. Helpful Professional Knowledgeable Confident
How should we listen?	Do not put clients on hold before listening to them. Be attentive Don't interrupt Use the customer's name.
Giving your name is important because:	Your client knows who they are talking to It shows you are prepared to take responsibility for handling their inquiry. It is an important first step in building a relationship with your client.
Why do we answer calls this way?	Good first impressions make our customers feel at ease and give them confidence in dealing with us.
Who should do it?	ALL STAFF

Managing Client Contacts

When clients contact us by telephone, we will take full responsibility for the process involved in meeting their needs.

What should we do?

Managing a Call

- Make notes as you speak and listen
- Answer your client's inquiry to the best of your ability - tell them all that they need to know, use product/service knowledge
- If you are unable to answer their query, or if it is a complex issue, escalate to the appropriate resource.
- Ensure your client understands what you have said by asking "Do you require any further information?" or "Does that make sense?"
Do not ask "Is that OK?" – this makes us sound like we are not confident in the advice or information we have provided
- Check if they feel satisfied that your explanation/information or promised actions meet their needs
- Summarize key points - tell the client what will happen next and sign off with your full name.
- All calls - wait for the client to disconnect first

Email Protocols

Email is a key Institute communication tool and must be used professionally and responsibly. All business-related emails are considered official records of the organization and must be managed in a manner consistent with records management requirements for the organization. Staff are responsible for:

- Checking their inbox regularly and responding within a reasonable timeframe (within 24 hours is recommended or an interim response should be issued to acknowledge the email)
- Ensuring the Microsoft 'out-of-office assistant' is used when away from your desk or working for an extended period (minimum one full working day)
- Include the original text as part of the response when replying to ensure a meaningful and contextual record is kept
- A complete email signature and disclaimer must be used for all new email correspondence
- Ensuring the email signature is used on all emails, including all internal, external, reply, and forward emails.

Email Etiquette

Emails must include and reflect the following:

- A relevant and suitable subject line to identify and summarize your correspondence
- Keep your email succinct and relevant, use plain English
- Address it to the person/s you want to respond to and cc: any other interested parties if appropriate
- Only use 'reply all' if everyone needs to receive your response
- Do not write in capitals as this is the equivalent of shouting unless you are using a relevant acronym
- Use correct punctuation, grammar, and spell check
- Ensure recipients' addresses are correct and follow up if you receive an 'error' message
- Do not use email as an excuse to avoid personal contact. Email communication isn't appropriate when sending confusing or emotional messages
- Remember emails are not always private, your email may be forwarded to unintended audiences so be always professional
- Be sparing with group responses, use the reply all button only when all people collectively need to see your response
- Do not forward chain emails, abrupt emails, or reply to spam
- Avoid the use of bcc (blind carbon copy) as it does not support open and transparent communication.

Our Standards of Service Excellence

- Providing unparalleled service is my role and the focus of our team efforts.
- I build and sustain trust by always demonstrating that I care.
- My appearance, behavior, and language reflect our brand excellence
- When I see a problem, I owe it until it is resolved.
- I build relationships that create clients for life.
- I embrace and foster diversity in teammates and clients
- I am always eager to assist my teammates by stepping out of my primary role to serve our clients
- I always conduct myself with strong character and integrity in protecting and elevating the ITWorks's name and reputation
- I am always gracious and treat clients and teammates with dignity and respect
- I enjoy what I do. I have a warm, happy, and caring attitude that creates a pleasant client experience
- I am trained and knowledgeable to provide excellent service to our clients
- I am prompt, reliable, and responsive. I complete my commitments on time, showing dedication and professionalism. I go beyond my clients' expectations.
- I am a leader. I lead by example. I am a role model at work, and I operate with uncompromising values.